Southern Utah: Another Tragedy (From Hurricane)

By Erin Cressida Wilson

INTRODUCTION

In the 1950's conflict in Korea caused the United States to consider testing nuclear weapons on a continental testing site in order to maintain U.S. nuclear weapons superiority. On 27 January 1951, a one-kiloton bomb dropped from an airplane and detonated over Frenchman Flat marked the beginning of atmospheric nuclear testing in Nevada.

Relatively few residents were aware of or concerned about nuclear testing when the first mushroom-shaped cloud rose into the western skies and drifted to the northeast, but the cloud figuratively remains over southern Utah and Nevada to this day. Residents live with every day what the cloud left behind that the eye could not see. There are no southwestern Utah neighborhoods or communities that have not been touched by the tragedy of cancer or birth defects or lingering bitterness over human and financial losses. Southern Utah: Another Tragedy from the play Hurricane by Erin Cressida Wilson

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ESTHER: I saw my first mushroom on a field trip. Miss Hansen took us to the edge of town and had us put our ears to the glass windows as we watched the mushroom cloud in the distance. I thought right there and then, I thought, "I'm marrying a man who works on those clouds, gonna hitch myself up with a fella who works those sky mushrooms." And that's exactly what I went and did. Yup. So now I'm worth one hundred thousand dollars! If I get the right kind of cancer that is. But then I'll never see that money. My family might, but I got no kin to speak of.

Now I don't claim to know much because I don't, but you know, they asked a bunch of kids, down there at the Hurricane Junior High

School, they asked these kids, you know, if they believed that there was such thing as the Holocaust. Well, you know their answer was "No." "No, no, no" was the firm answer of theirs. They thought it was a myth like the Easter Rabbit or Santy Claus. Well, they used their skin for lamps, made shades with human flesh, knocked out their teeth for gold, you know, and they would take their hair and make wigs. But how you gonna convince a kid from Hurricane, Utah that that really happened? We're good at forgetting. Painting over the sore spots. Hey, but I'm stupid.

Well, now, this is something, you know, Graham, my husband, he excavated the ground after the nuclear tests used to go off, you know, cleared the area, and brought cans of water to the soldiers. Water's the best thing to wash off with in cases of radiation exposure. Just plain water. That's right. And sometimes, there'd be these days when they'd stop him from entering. They'd stop him in his car. They were waiting for the wind to shift, that's right, they were waiting for the wind to change. So it could blow east. Towards Southern Utah, Hurricane, St. George, and the likes. But not towards California and Los Angeles. That's a fact. Because California was a real place, a real place back then where things were happening. But in any case, the point is that this land here, in Utah, that my grandfather homesteaded and had took away from him in the Great Depression, this land was designated by the United States government as, and I know this now, as perfect and

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useless, yes. Disposable. The land. The people. A place you might throw out your used razor blades.

It's not my husband I mourn so much, but don't get me wrong, cause I do, it's my daughter, born with her heart outside her body. Now you know I'm stupid 'cause I don't know why, but I always return to this land, return to Hurricane, where the rocks have faces and the wind is hot, where the dry heat and the sulfur springs make you high. Around here the streams bubble hot, there are prehistoric fossils, the bottom of the ocean was here once, you can find shells up there, and there's a good road up there you can go up to the mesa with a six pack and watch the meteors. But what I love the most is that underneath this beauty lurks the memory and reality that the grass will turn brown under your feet and that if you hold your fingers up you can see your bones. And you can taste it, sure, taste it on your tongue, like metal . . . like sex, the sky is pink. And now the moonlight is even too bright for me and these eyes. You think I got a hair left on my head? You think my teeth ain't real? They discovered they were hollow, that's right, no nerves, no blood, as they pulled them out, one by one, and gave me a new set to drop into a glass of water each night.

Oh, it's silly, but I remember learning, in the encyclopedia it was, I remember learning that crocodiles, they make hundreds of teeth

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their whole life, hundreds of teeth-wish I did-they just fall out and grow back, fall out and grow back, and they uhm, they, the men, they would take the teeth, this was back at the turn of the century or some such time, they used to take the teeth and cause they were hollow, they filled them with gunpowder, this is a fact, and used them as ammunition, as bullets, imagine. Crocodile teeth as ammunition. I feel like they stuck those crocodile teeth in my head and turned my skin the color of the rainbow, pulled my scalp up with the comb and cut my voice box, cut it right out of me.

Can you imagine burning rabbits running across a field, and sheep, homes split down the middle and cattle on fire, poison milk, children born with no faces, just large holes, the heat of seven suns, 125 atomic blasts detonated in Nevada between '51 and '62, each one about the same size as that Chernobyl. And my voice box cut right out of me. I never was a very good talker anyway, but I always knew how to think, quietly, to myself, stupid, but I thought, as I straightened the cuffs on Graham's pants leg before throwing them into the washer, the poison dust from his cuffs on my fingers, the taste of the pink cloud, like sex, and I am quiet, and I think you can hear me Claire, hear my loud whisper, your heart I touched in my hand when you were born, outside your body and how you did not live to see twenty-four hours ... your face, a hole your heart, in the stones, your touch, in the stream, your torso in the stars, your hair in the wind on my lips, your face .....

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I think she'd be thirty years old now, she would be. He'd be sixty. Ha!

One dusk I saw a flock of mourning doves flying. A flock of mourning doves. And they had just flown by the light of a mushroom, that spitfire light of the mushroom, and they just dove, these mourning doves, they just dove straight into the light and died, kamikazied, a whole flock of mourning doves were blinded by this light that they relentlessly stared at. Maybe they was smart. You see, they thought the light was water, that it was the water that would hold them. But you could say I was one of those mourning doves. Or just stupid. Just staring into that light over and over and over and over again. Proud to be a part of it I guess. Or just proud to be able to accept anything that comes my way. I'm worth one hundred thousand dollars with the right kind of cancer. But don't listen to me. If I knew then what I know now, well ... when you're dumb you're dumb. Right?

Claire, I'm happy. I don't watch the news, I don't take no bull, I'm a survivor and you know, Honey, do you know, you never got to see that mushroom, but it was like heaven, it was like heaven above. In that trailer, next to that butte, the glass and the heat of the day, the shudder of the window and the look of heaven, man-made

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heaven in the sky, in the south of Utah, in the mid-I950S, the baldness of neighbors, things you could not conceive, squinting our eyes up to Salt Lake City as we wondered the half life of atoms. And I think in this tiny town, I think about how we marvel at the news of war and in a way feel filled by it cause it's over there, over there, and Hitler, he's not just over there, he's way back then. Why it is that they chose this land I will never know and why it is that we don't count I'll never know, but we bombed our own country. But when you're dumb you're dumb, right. Hey, I'm no activist. I'm just sitting in this bar, right, drinking this beer, right, quiet as a mouse. Shhh.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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